

A GUIDE FROM THE INVESTOR'S SIDE OF THE TABLE

The Pitch Deck Playbook

What actually earns a second meeting, written for young entrepreneurs by someone who reads decks all day and rarely finishes most of them.

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NOTE BEFORE YOU START

From my side of the table

I have read a lot of decks. Some good, most forgettable, a few I still think about. Almost every deck that failed, failed for the same reason: not a bad idea, not a bad market. Too many slides, no clear line of thought, or the one thing I actually cared about was buried on page nine instead of page two.

I recently judged the SEE Pakistan Regional Round, and it confirmed what years of reading decks had already taught me: the founders who stood out were not the ones with the most slides or the fanciest design. They were the ones who respected my time and told a story I could follow in one sitting.

"Chaliye shuru karte hain." Let's begin.

LENGTH

How long should your deck be

8–10

slides in total

3

minutes of real
attention on a first
read

30pt

minimum font size
on any slide

1

idea allowed
per slide

12+

slides starts to
feel unfinished

10 sharp slides beat twenty-five soft ones.

STRUCTURE

The slide order that works

01 Cover Company name and one line that says what you do.

02 Problem The pain point, plain enough for a stranger to get in ten seconds.

03 Solution Your answer to that problem, described simply.

04 Market size How big is the opportunity. Show the numbers that matter.

05 Demo Show the product itself. This is where belief starts.

06 Business model How you actually make money, in one clear sentence.

07 Traction (optional) Users, revenue, pilots. Skip it at idea stage.

08 Competition Who else is here, and what makes you different.

09 Team Who is building this, and why you're the right people.

10 Financials (optional) Add once you are actually generating revenue.

11 Contact Your name, email, and the one thing you want next.

A SPECIAL CASE

When you only get five minutes

Move your team slide to page two, right after the cover.

When all you have is an idea, the business itself is unproven by definition. The real question in the room is not "is this a good business." It is "are these the people who can build a good business out of this." Put your team up front. Show the reason this specific group is the one to trust with this specific problem. Everything else becomes easier to believe once the room already believes in you.

"Log paise idea mein nahi, banda dekh kar lagate hain."

People do not fund an idea, they fund the person standing behind it.

The four acts

A good deck moves through four acts. This keeps every slide honest and stops two ideas from sharing one slide.

Act one: The hook

You earn the right to keep talking.

Cover · Problem · Solution

Act two: The business

You show there is a real business here.

Market size · Demo · Business model

Act three: The proof

You show it can actually be built and won.

Traction · Competition · Team

Act four: The close

You tell the reader exactly what to do next.

Financials · Contact

THE ONE RULE THAT MATTERS MOST

Your slides should never be just text

If a slide could be read out loud as a paragraph, it is not a slide. It is a page from a report. A slide is a visual aid to what you're saying, not a script for it.

WALL OF TEXT

Our product is an AI credit engine built for small businesses. It uses transaction and mobile data to score creditworthiness in real time. Small business owners often get rejected by banks because they lack collateral or formal records. Our system approves or declines an application in minutes instead of weeks. It also monitors repayment behavior automatically. We plan to add supplier financing in the next release.

Six lines nobody reads on a screen from the back row.

ONE IDEA, ONE GLANCE

CREDIT DECISIONS

Days

Before



90 sec

After, with the platform

72%

more approvals for thin-file
small businesses using the platform

The rest, you say out loud.

REFERENCE

A sample deck, built end to end

The same eleven-slide order from earlier, applied to a fictional fintech company called CredX — one of the most common problems in finance today: small businesses that banks won't lend to. Use it as a starting layout, not a copy-paste template.

CredX

Credit that meets small business where it is

Problem • Solution • Market • Team • Ask



Problem

The pain point in one sentence

65%

of small and mid-size businesses in emerging markets are denied credit by traditional banks. Locked out for lacking collateral, not for lacking a viable business.

Source: IFC / World Bank SME Finance Gap estimates. Figure illustrative for this example.



Solution

Your answer, kept simple

1

Analyze

Read transaction, mobile, and utility data instead of paperwork

2

Score

Generate a real-time credit score in under 90 seconds

3

Disburse

Send funds directly, no branch visit required



Market Size

Sizing the opportunity

TAM

\$5.2T

Global SME credit gap

SAM

\$380B

South Asia SME credit gap

SOM

\$45M

Pakistan target segment, yr 1–3

Figures illustrative, built for this example from public SME finance-gap research.

04

Demo

Show, do not tell



Ninety-second walkthrough of the live loan approval flow.

Not screenshots of slides.



Business Model

How you make money

Micro

2.0%

origination fee, per loan under \$2k

Growth

1.5%

origination fee, plus 4–8% APR
spread

Enterprise

Custom

white-label scoring for partner
banks



Traction (Optional)

What is already working

25,000

loans disbursed

\$18M

total capital deployed

92%

on-time repayment rate

8

cities live

All figures are illustrative examples for layout purposes only.



Competition

Who else, and why you

	Traditional banks	CredX
Approval time	2–4 weeks	Under 2 minutes
Uses alternative data	No	Yes
Works without collateral	No	Yes
Branch visit required	Yes	No



Team

Built by operators



Arqam Hussain

Founder & CEO

Ships the roadmap



Head of Risk

Ex-banking credit lead

Built scoring models for 2 banks



Banking Advisor

Twelve years in the industry

Opens doors with regulators



Financials (Optional)

Only once revenue is real

\$85K

monthly recurring revenue

22%

month-over-month growth

16

months of runway left

All figures on this page are illustrative examples for layout purposes only.

TOOLS

Design it with AI

You do not need a design background to make a clean deck. These two tools cover most of what a first-time founder needs.

DESIGN TOOL

Gamma

Turn a rough outline into a fully designed deck in minutes. It handles layout, spacing, and visuals for you, so you can focus on getting the words right first.

THINKING PARTNER

Claude

Talk through your story, tighten your headlines, stress test your numbers, and build supporting visuals right inside the conversation before you move anything into slides.

Investor's take: Use Claude to sharpen the thinking and the words. Use Gamma to make it look finished. Neither replaces knowing your own numbers cold.

BEFORE YOU CLOSE THE LAPTOP

A last word

None of this replaces a strong business underneath the slides. A great deck cannot save a weak idea, but a weak deck can bury a great one before anyone finds out how good it really is.

Build it tight. Practice it out loud. Cut the slide you are most attached to and see if the story still holds without it. If it does, you did not need that slide.

***"Himmat rakhein, mehnat dikhayen. Baaqi khud ba khud samajh jayenge."
Stay confident, show the work. The rest will follow on its own.***